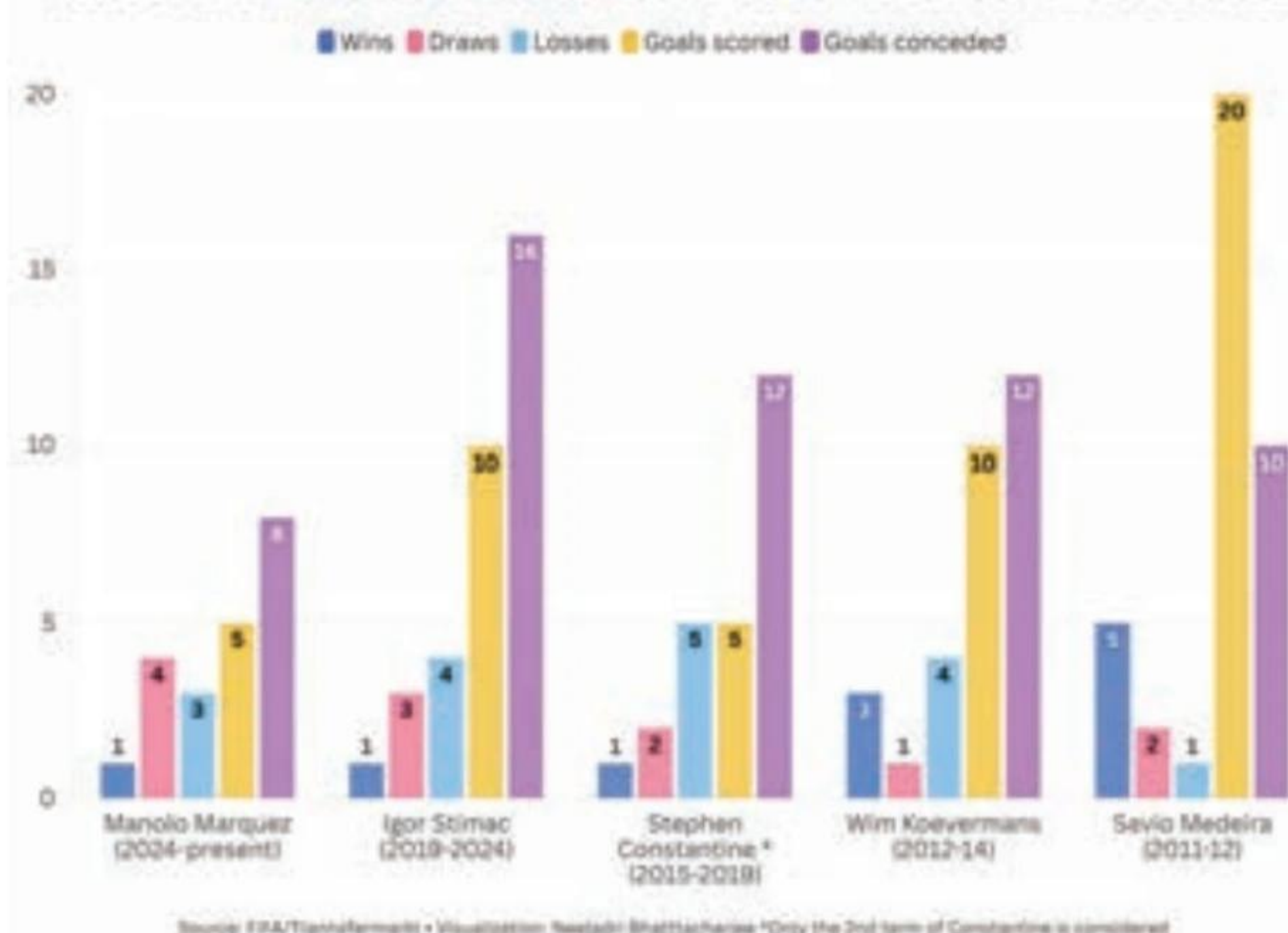


Record of last five India head coaches after 8 matches



how to get the entire structure in line and get football completely aligned with grassroots development,” Bhutia says.

“All hope is not lost yet. We have to focus more and more on youth development, and a turnaround is still possible,” an optimistic Subrata quips.

A notable example here would be Uzbekistan. Ranked just two spots above India in 2018, it invested heavily in youth football, spending about USD 1.4 million a year, allotted to it through the FIFA Forward Programme, between 2016 and 2021.

It won the U-23 AFC Asian Cup in 2018, the U-20 Asian Cup in 2023, and eventually qualified for its first-ever senior men’s World Cup in 2025.

An alternative solution

Another remedy for quick-fire results would be the use of Indian-origin and naturalised players.

Qatar has championed this method, winning consecutive AFC Asian Cups with the help of naturalised personnel — most importantly Almoez Ali, its top scorer in the 2019 campaign, who was born in Sudan but was naturalised in 2013.

India’s last opponent, Hong Kong, qualified for the 2023 AFC Asian Cup after 55 years using naturalised players. At the tournament, it had the joint-most number of naturalised players, 14, tied with Malaysia.

Of the 23 players in its squad for the India game, 11 were naturalised, having given up the passports of their native countries to switch nationalities and obtain

naturalisation in Hong Kong. Six of them constituted the starting 11.

Thailand, on the other hand, aggressively scouted foreign players of Thai origin to qualify for consecutive knockouts in the Asian Cup for the first time.

Dual citizenship is not allowed in India under the Constitution and the Citizenship Act of 1955. So, Overseas Citizens of India (OCI) and Persons of Indian Origin (PIO) must surrender their foreign passports and stay in the country for at least 12 months to apply for an Indian passport.

“It is a huge handicap because there are many good players of Indian origin playing in the top leagues of Europe. So it could be a huge help if we speak about bigger achievements,” Stimac had said during the AFC Asian Cup.

“The AIFF is in communication with 33 players who fall into the category of OCI,” Chaubey said in a press conference on June 13. “We are committed to aligning with the laws of the land and the framework of the FIFA statutes for the inclusion of OCI players in India,” he added in the presser.

The chaos is not just technical — it’s cultural.

“We need stories for young generations to watch and get inspired. We got it from our previous generations and from very good coaches (like PK Banerjee, Amal Dutta),” Subrata says.

“Where are such stories now? How will the motivation come?”

At the 1952 Olympics, India lost 1–10 to Czechoslovakia. It was one of the chapters that was looked down on as ‘Never Again!’

The Blue Tigers achieved their best-ever finish at the next Olympic Games, finishing fourth, and then clinched gold at the 1962 Asian Games, beating Japan and South Korea in the process.

Over half a century after its golden era, Indian football now faces its darkest hour. Unless it tears down the rot and rebuilds from ruin, Indian football’s legacy will become its tombstone — like the shattered Parthenon, its ruins whispering of wasted potential.

Internationals played between June 2024-June 2025

